C11W6 · THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 26, 2026

LANDING PAGES + DEMAND GEN

Critique, Prompting, and Driving Traffic

PART 1: LANDING PAGE REVIEW

QUICK STATUS CHECK

- Who has a **live landing page** right now?
- Who's **still working** on getting it deployed?
- Who's **stuck** on hosting, design, or deployment?

> 💡 If you're stuck on hosting: **Vercel, Netlify, GitHub Pages** (free, deploy in minutes with a code agent). **Carrd** ($19/yr, no code). We'll talk about it.

BEST PRACTICES FOR LANDING PAGES

⚠️ A landing page is **not** a marketing homepage. It has **one job:** drive a specific action.

🎯 FOCUS ON ONE PROBLEM

- Name the specific pain point
- List how you solve it
- Have everything support this particular message

CLEAR CALL TO ACTION

- CTA = **join the waitlist** (that's it for now)
- Above the fold, obvious, impossible to miss
- Every section should lead back to it

- **Scannable in seconds** — a visitor should get it without reading every word
- **Streamline toward one action** — no nav bars, no "learn more," no distractions

PART 2: FEATURE FORGE

FEATURE-FORGE: THE FULL LIFECYCLE

Every feature you build follows these 7 phases.

1. FEATURE BRIEF
Define the problem

2. ARCHITECTURE
Design the solution

3. PLAN
Break into phases

4. IMPLEMENT
Write code + tests

5. REVIEW
Structured code review

6. PUSH
PR + CI/CD + deploy

7. CLEANUP
Measure + improve

💡 **Phases 1-3 are documentation.** You write before you code. The AI reads your docs and builds exactly what you described. This is how you get quality output instead of generic code.

THE DOCUMENTATION STACK

Each feature creates a folder with 4 documents.

01_BRIEF

What and **why**? Goal, user stories, requirements, success metrics, non-goals

02_ARCHITECTURE

How? Components, data flows, alternatives considered (and rejected), edge cases

03_PLAN

In what order? Phased tasks, test list from requirements, definition of done

04_PROGRESS

What's happening? Living log — updated continuously, tracks done/remaining/results

💡 **These docs are what the AI agent reads.** Better docs = better code. The agent builds from your specification, not from guessing.

STOP GATES: HUMAN APPROVAL

🛑

AFTER BRIEF

- Problem defined correctly?
- Success metrics right?
- Building the right thing?

🛑

AFTER ARCHITECTURE

- Design make sense?
- Alternatives considered?
- Missing edge cases?

🛑

AFTER PLAN

- Build order logical?
- Tests cover requirements?
- Ready to go?

⚠️ **No code gets written until you approve all three.** This is how you avoid "the AI built what I was asking for, but also changed a bunch of stuff I didn't want it to."

THE AI DOESN'T FAIL AT CODING. IT FAILS AT UNDERSTANDING WHAT YOU WANT.

Documentation is how you close that gap.

LANDING PAGE: YOUR FIRST FEATURE-FORGE

BRIEF (10 MIN)

- One job: collect waitlist emails
- Sections: hero, benefits, CTA
- Success metric: X signups/week
- Non-goal: not the actual product

ARCHITECTURE (5 MIN)

- Email: Formspree / Supabase / Sheets
- Thank-you page (ad tracking)
- GA pixel + UTM params
- Hosting: Vercel / Netlify / Carrd

PLAN (5 MIN)

- Phase 1: Static page + hero + CTA
- Phase 2: Wire up email capture
- Phase 3: Thank-you + analytics
- Phase 4: Deploy + verify

20 minutes of planning → the AI builds exactly what you need.

In the Build phase, features get bigger. This process gets more important.

YOUR TECH STACK

Framework + Hosting

USE A FRAMEWORK

FRONTEND FRAMEWORK

React · Next.js · Vite

- Modern component-based UI development
- Fast development with hot reload
- Massive ecosystem of libraries
- AI agents understand them extremely well
- Easy to deploy on Vercel/Netlify

BACKEND FRAMEWORK

Django · Rails · Supabase

- Django/Rails: Full backend with auth, DB, admin
- Supabase: Database + auth + APIs as a service
- Both options: proven, well-documented
- AI agents can build with either approach
- Deploy backend on Railway
- Amplitude for product analytics

💡 **This is a web stack.** If you're building mobile apps or something else, mostly ignore this slide — you'll need a different stack. But for web-based products, this is the path.

HOSTING: RAILWAY

RAILWAY.APP — RECOMMENDED FOR EVERYTHING

- Deploy your React/Next.js frontend
- Deploy your Django/Rails backend (or connect Supabase)
- Database included (Postgres)
- Auto-deploys from GitHub
- Free tier is enough for MVP validation
- Scales when you need it

💡 **Consolidate your hosting.** You *can* host your landing page on Vercel/Netlify/Carrd, but I recommend moving towards Railway for everything — simpler to manage, one place to deploy and monitor.

THE RECOMMENDED STACK

React/Next.js + Supabase + Railway + GitHub

Push to GitHub → Railway auto-deploys → live in seconds

FRONTEND

React / Next.js

Modern UI framework

BACKEND

Supabase

Database + auth + APIs

HOSTING

Railway

Auto-deploy from GitHub

VERSION CONTROL

GitHub

Team workflow

HOW TO MAKE VISUALS WITH LLMS

VISUALS FOR LANDING PAGES

AI-GENERATED

Best for:

- Hero backgrounds
- Conceptual shots
- Lifestyle imagery

STOCK PHOTOS

Best for:

- Real people
- Real environments
- Professional settings

SCREENSHOTS

Best for:

- Product demos
- Feature walkthroughs
- Future state mockups

HTML/CSS

Best for:

- Icons and graphics
- Diagrams and charts
- Geometric patterns

ANATOMY OF AN IMAGE PROMPT

GLOBAL STYLE PREFIX

Copy-paste at the top of EVERY prompt

- Art style / medium (illustration, photo, minimal)
- Your brand colors as **hex codes**
- Composition rules (edge-to-edge, no borders)
- What to avoid (no photorealism, no stock look)

SCENE DETAILS

Unique to each image

- **Scene:** What's happening, who, where
- **Color emphasis:** Which brand colors dominate
- **Mood:** Be explicit — "HAPPY," "confident," not vague
- **Composition:** Shot type, figure placement, lighting

💡 **The style prefix is your consistency engine.** Same prefix on every prompt = cohesive visual identity across all images. Pull it directly from your STYLE_GUIDE.md.

⚠️ **Use technical language from photography and graphic design.** Terms like "shallow depth of field," "rule of thirds," "soft lighting," "high key," or "complementary colors" produce dramatically better results than casual descriptions.

EXAMPLE: STYLE PREFIX FROM TEXT AFFIRMATIONS

GLOBAL STYLE PREFIX — paste this at the top of every image prompt:

Warm editorial illustration in gouache painting style. Edge-to-edge composition filling the entire canvas. Matte finish, visible brushstrokes, flat areas of rich color. Soft, slightly abstracted figures suggested through posture and gesture. No detailed facial features. Rich color palette dominated by **teal blue (#32a2b7)**, **saffron yellow (#E1BC29)**, **tea green (#CBF3D2)**, and **charcoal gray (#4f4f4f)**. Organic rounded shapes in backgrounds. Warm directional light from the left. No photorealism, no 3D rendering, no hyperrealism, no sharp edges, no stock photo composition. Hand-painted editorial magazine illustration quality. No borders, no frames, no paper texture edges, no rounded corners. The illustration must extend fully to all four edges of the image. Keep the main subject centered with some breathing room so it can be cropped without losing the subject.

THEN ADD SCENE DETAILS

- **SCENE:** Woman sitting on couch with phone, early morning, soft window light
- **COLOR EMPHASIS:** Teal in her sweater, saffron in the window glow, tea green background
- **MOOD:** CONTENTMENT, quiet joy, peaceful moment
- **FIGURES:** Mid-30s woman, relaxed posture, legs tucked under, soft smile
- **COMPOSITION:** Medium shot, rule of thirds, negative space on right
- **AVOID:** No detailed facial features, no stock photo smile

WHY THIS WORKS

- Style prefix = **consistency** across all images
- Hex codes = **exact brand colors** every time
- Technical terms = **professional results**
- Explicit mood = **no emotional misfires**
- Same prefix, different scenes = **cohesive asset bank**

IMAGE GENERATION WORKFLOW

1

WRITE YOUR STYLE PREFIX

Based on your style guide. Art direction + hex colors + composition rules. One paragraph you reuse everywhere.

2

LIST THE IMAGES YOU NEED

Use AI to help plan this. Hero, feature sections, about. Plan the full set before generating.

3

GENERATE MULTIPLES PER SCENE

Portrait + landscape. Build an asset bank, not just one image per slot. Same prompt in different sessions produces different results — try multiple times to see variations.

4

KEEP EVERYTHING

Each image is an asset. You'll reuse them for ads, social, future pages.

PART 3: DEMAND GEN STRATEGIES

Beyond Paid Ads

THE CHANNEL LANDSCAPE

PAID

Money → Attention

- Social ads (Meta, TikTok): ~$0.70/click
- Search ads (Google): ~$5.26/click
- Influencer partnerships

Tuesday's playbook (Mike Fynn)

EARNED

Quality → Amplification

- Word of mouth (3-5x conversion rate)
- Referral programs
- Press / PR mentions

Hardest to control, highest trust

OWNED

Effort → Compounding

- Social media (organic)
- Email list
- Content / SEO (long-term)

Free, compounds over time

💡 **Full funnel: $100 on Meta = 143 clicks → 3-7 waitlist signups** (at 2-5% conversion). Same $100 on Google = 19 clicks → 0-1 signups. Social ads first for volume; search ads later when people are searching for you.

THE MARKETING FUNNEL

1

AWARENESS

They discover you exist (ads, social posts, search, referrals)

2

INTEREST

They click to your landing page and read about the problem/solution

3

CONVERSION

They sign up for your waitlist (give you their email)

4

RETENTION

They stay engaged through email nurture until MVP launch

⚠️ **Your current goal: Awareness → Conversion.** Get traffic to your landing page, convert visitors to email signups. Retention starts after you have signups.

SOCIAL MEDIA: THE REACH REALITY

WHERE ORGANIC REACH STILL WORKS

- **TikTok:** Highest organic reach, engagement up 49% YoY
- **Instagram Reels:** ~3.5% reach per post, Reels get 50% boost
- **LinkedIn (personal profiles):** 561% more reach than company pages
- **Reddit:** 430M+ monthly users, 1,348% Google visibility growth

WHERE IT'S DYING

- **LinkedIn company pages:** Down 60-66% reach since 2024
- **Facebook pages:** 1.65% reach, down 17% YoY
- **Instagram static posts:** Down 12% YoY

Company pages are dead. Personal profiles win.

⚠️ **Post as yourself, not as the company.** Company pages are needed for credibility, but posting from your personal profile gets 5x the engagement on the exact same content.

BE A FOUNDER POSTING ABOUT YOUR STARTUP,
NOT A STARTUP POSTING ABOUT ITSELF.

Personal profiles: 561% more reach. 5x more engagement.
Same content.

COMMUNITY + LAUNCH CHANNELS

REDDIT + NICHE COMMUNITIES

- 430M+ monthly users, 20+ min avg visit
- Be a genuine member first — Reddit punishes self-promo
- Answer questions, share insights, then mention what you're building
- AMAs are effective for founders

Find your audience's subreddit. Contribute first.

PRODUCT HUNT

- 60-75% of traffic in first 3 days, then drops sharply
- Top launches: 15-25% visitor-to-signup conversion
- Must have conversion mechanism ready BEFORE launch
- Better for MVP launch (Week 7-8) than today

One shot. Make it count.

💡 **Also consider:** Hacker News, Indie Hackers, niche Slack/Discord groups, Columbia alumni networks. Go where YOUR audience already is.

HOW TO USE REDDIT (WITHOUT GETTING BANNED)

1

FIND 2-3 SUBREDDITS WHERE YOUR USERS HANG OUT

Search Reddit for your problem space. Join subreddits with active discussions.

2

PARTICIPATE GENUINELY FOR 1-2 WEEKS FIRST

Answer questions. Share insights. Build karma. Don't mention your product yet.

3

SHARE YOUR LANDING PAGE WHEN IT'S GENUINELY RELEVANT

Someone asks about your problem? "I'm building X to solve this, here's the waitlist."

4

OR POST AN AMA ABOUT WHAT YOU LEARNED BUILDING IT

"I'm building X for Y problem. Here's what I learned interviewing 50 users."

⚠️ **Don't post the same link across multiple subreddits.** Reddit's spam filters will shadow-ban you. One genuine post in the right subreddit > ten spammy posts.

EMAIL: THE BRIDGE

Paid traffic is temporary. Your email list is permanent.

Every visitor who doesn't sign up is lost forever.

WHY EMAIL WINS

- Nurtured leads: 50% more sales-ready, 33% lower cost
- Nurtured leads make 47% larger purchases
- 4-10x response rate vs. generic email blasts

YOUR WAITLIST MINIMUM

- Email capture on your landing page (today)
- Welcome email (automated, this week)
- Update emails as you build (weekly)

YOUR EMAIL PLAYBOOK (4 EMAILS)

EMAIL 1: WELCOME (IMMEDIATE)

Subject: "You're on the waitlist"
Body: Thank them. Tell them what happens next. Ask them to reply with their biggest pain point.

EMAIL 2: FOUNDER STORY (3 DAYS LATER)

Subject: "Why I'm building this"
Body: Personal story. The problem you experienced. Why you care. Builds trust.

EMAIL 3: PROGRESS UPDATE (1 WEEK LATER)

Subject: "Early look at what we're building"
Body: Show progress. Screenshot or mockup. "Here's what's working." Invite feedback.

EMAIL 4: MVP LAUNCH (WHEN READY)

Subject: "You're the first to try it"
Body: "It's live. You're getting early access before anyone else. Here's the link."

💡 **Tool:** Mailchimp free tier (up to 500 contacts). Set up automated welcome email this week. Other 3 emails can be manual for now.

REFERRAL TACTICS (TURN 1 SIGNUP INTO 2)

THE OFFER

On your waitlist confirmation page:

- "Share with a friend → both get early access"
- Or: "Refer 3 friends → skip the line"
- Or: "First 10 referrers get free premium features"

Dual-sided incentives work best (both people get something).

THE MECHANIC

Give each person a unique share link:

- yourapp.com/?ref=john123
- Track signups from that link
- Email them when someone joins via their link

Tools: Viral Loops, KickoffLabs (free tiers exist).

⚠️ **The math:** If 20% of your signups refer 1 friend, you get 20% more signups for free. Dropbox went from 100K to 4M users in 15 months with referrals.

BLOG CONTENT (BUILD LONG-TERM SEO)

WHAT TO WRITE

- **Problem-focused:** "5 reasons college students struggle with internships"
- **Founder journey:** "What I learned from 50 user interviews"
- **Solution explainer:** "How we're fixing X problem"
- **Tactical advice:** "A guide to [something your audience needs]"

WHERE TO PUBLISH

- **Your own site:** Best for SEO and owning the traffic
- **Medium/Substack:** Built-in audience discovery
- **LinkedIn articles:** Native reach to your network
- **Dev.to/Hashnode:** If you're building for developers

💡 **Distribution is more important than perfection.** Write 1 post, share it everywhere: LinkedIn, Reddit (where relevant), Twitter, email list. A good post shared 5 places beats 5 posts shared nowhere.

INFLUENCER OUTREACH (BORROW AN AUDIENCE)

1

IDENTIFY 10-20 MICRO-INFLUENCERS IN YOUR SPACE

Not celebrities — people with 5K-50K followers who post about your problem space.

2

FOLLOW, ENGAGE GENUINELY FOR 1-2 WEEKS

Comment on their posts. Share their content. Build a relationship before you ask for anything.

3

SEND A SHORT, PERSONALIZED DM

"I built X for [problem]. Your audience deals with this. Would you try it and share feedback?" Offer early access, not payment.

4

MAKE IT EASY FOR THEM

Send them a pre-written post they can edit. Include your landing page link, images, and a hook.

⚠️ **Micro-influencers > celebrities.** A person with 10K engaged followers in your niche will drive more signups than a celebrity with 1M followers who don't care about your problem.

CHANNELS FEED EACH OTHER

1

PAID ADS → LANDING PAGE → EMAIL LIST

$100 test drives traffic. Some convert. Others join your list.

2

ORGANIC SOCIAL → BRAND AWARENESS → CHEAPER PAID ADS

People click on names they recognize. Your founder posts lower your ad costs.

3

EMAIL NURTURE → CONVERSION → WORD OF MOUTH

Nurture your list. Convert when your product is ready. Happy users tell friends.

💡 **This is a system, not a checklist.** Teams that understand how channels compound will outperform teams that think demand gen is "running some ads."

YOUR WEEK 6 PLAYBOOK

THIS WEEK

- **Launch paid test** — Mike's $100 blueprint
- **Founder posts** — personal LinkedIn/IG/TikTok
- **Email capture** — waitlist form live on page
- **Seed community** — 2-3 relevant subreddits/groups

WEEK 7-8 (BUILD PHASE)

- **Analyze ad data** — adjust page/messaging
- **Social cadence** — 3-5 posts/week, show the build
- **First email** — update your waitlist
- **Product Hunt** — when MVP is ready

💡 **Signups are the only metric that matters this week.** Not views. Not likes. Not impressions. Email captures.

PART 4: WORK BLOCK

WORK PRIORITIES

1

FIX LANDING PAGE ISSUES

Apply what we saw in the critique. Hero, CTA, visuals.

2

GENERATE BETTER IMAGES

Use your style guide in image prompts. Replace stock photos.

3

DRAFT YOUR DEMAND GEN STRATEGY

Which channels? What's your first post? When do ads go live?

4

KICK OFF YOUR DEMAND GEN

Start driving traffic. Paid ads, founder posts, community seeding — whatever you chose. Go live this week.

5

DRAFT YOUR MVP FEATURE LIST

What features do you need for v1? Start documenting the MVP scope.

PART 5: WRAP

THE COUNTDOWN TO MVP

2 weeks

UNTIL MVP PRESENTATIONS

March 12 (c15w8)

March 16

SPRING BREAK

MVPs must be functional before break

THIS WEEK + NEXT

- Landing pages live, driving traffic
- Demand test running ($100 blueprint)
- Founder posts on organic channels
- **Tuesday (c12w7):** Build phase starts

WEEK 8 (MAR 10-12)

- Build sprint continues
- Review experiment 2 results
- **Thursday (c15w8): MVP Presentations**
- Peer feedback before spring break

WHAT'S NEXT

THIS WEEK

- Landing pages **live and getting traffic**
- Launch paid demand test ($100 blueprint)
- Post on your organic channel
- **Draft MVP feature list** — what features for v1?
- Continue Google Analytics cert

NEXT TUESDAY (C12W7)

- **Start building the real product**
- Dev workflow intro (CLAUDE.md, git, feature-forge)
- WoZ / concierge for hard problems
- The Build phase begins

⚠️ **MVP feature list = your build plan.** List what features you need for a functional v1. Each feature will go through feature-forge (brief, architecture, plan, implement). Start with 3-5 core features.

🎧 **Podcast:** Demand Gen: Paid vs Earned vs Organic — listen before next Thursday (c13w7)

ADMINISTRATIVE NOTE: FINAL EXAM

The final exam will be held in the normal slot:

Monday, May 12th at 1:10 PM

Currently listed on the registrar's website

TWO WEEKS TO MVP.

THE REAL WORLD GETS A VOTE STARTING TODAY.

END OF CLASS 11

Next: Start Building · Dev Workflows · The Build Phase